great oceans would be irrelevant if Europe and Asia were both dominated by aggressive empires, thus isolating the country from global trade and threatening its ultimate security. To Spykman, continental defense (what he called "quarter-sphere" defense) was unviable without full hemispheric defense, including South America; that, in turn, could not be ensured without a favorable balance of power in both Europe and Asia in the Eastern Hemisphere.[22] Thus, American forces had to be present in those far-flung regions, which became part of the argument for near-permanent forward basing of US troops in both Europe and Asia after 1945.

This shift in strategic thinking led to concrete planning for the postwar era, forming the basis for US policy in the Pacific throughout the Cold War and beyond. Beginning with the need to neutralize a potential future Japanese threat, the first two pillars of Washington's strategy were the permanent militarization of the US presence in Asia and the democratization of Japan. The US occupation of Japan from 1945 to 1952 ensured that both these approaches became the basis of US policy.[23] The outbreak of the Korean War, in June 1950, further spurred a military-first strategy for Asia, while reinforcing the containment of Soviet-sponsored communism as the third major pillar of US strategy, as already codified in the then top secret NSC-68 document of April 1950. The threat of communist subversion in newly decolonized Asia led to the fourth element of US strategy, which was to create a regionwide system of defensive alliances.[24] Between 1951 and 1960, Washington would sign a series of formal security treaties, attempting to create a network of multilateral agreements mirroring those in Europe, including the Australia–New Zealand–United States (ANZUS) Treaty in 1951 and the Southeast Asia Treaty Organization (SEATO) in 1954.

The US multilateral treaty system did not succeed in Asia, with SEATO and ANZUS breaking apart, ultimately leading instead to enduring bilateral alliances with Australia (1951), the Philippines (1951), South Korea (1953), Thailand (1954), and Japan (1960). American forces were anchored by major air and naval bases located in Japan in the northeast, and the Philippines in the southeast. These strategically located and